

Virtuosity

The Romantic period saw the rise of the virtuoso soloist who played in private salons and in newly built concert halls. Traveling around Europe, they would be greeted by crowds of fans. Among these, the most famous soloists were Italian violinist Niccolò Paganini and Hungarian pianist Franz Liszt.



△ Violin quadruple stopping

Also a composer, Paganini created many special violin effects, including quadruple stopping where the performer plays all four strings together as a chord.

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Nationalism

Political upheaval and conflict in Europe encouraged nations to rediscover their individual cultural heritage. In music, this meant using folk tunes as inspiration for music, and imitating the special sonorities of folk instruments.

Keywork based on saxophone

Key for left-hand little finger



▷ Tárogató

Resembling a wooden soprano saxophone, the tárogató is a popular folk instrument in Hungary, though its ancient origins are in the Turkish double-reed shawm.

Opera

Romantic opera was dominated by Giuseppe Verdi and Richard Wagner. Verdi's Italian operas have arias, ensembles, recitatives, choruses, and dramatic stories. On the other hand, Wagner's German operas are longer and "through composed," with no distinct break between arias, recitative, ensembles, and instrumental interludes.

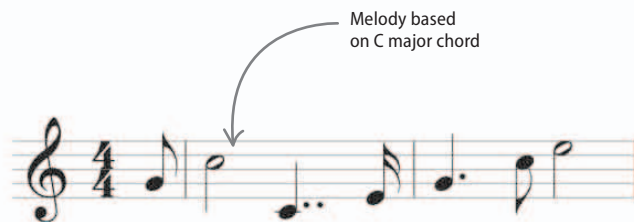


Melisma on "dorate" (gilded)

Va, pen - sie - ro, sul-l'a - li do - ra - - te, va, ti

△ "Va, pensiero" by Verdi

"Va, pensiero" (Chorus of the Hebrew Slaves), from the 1841 opera *Nabucco*, became famous in Italy as a nationalist anthem. Its popularity was the equivalent of a modern pop hit.



Melody based on C major chord

△ Wagner's motifs

Wagner used special tunes, or leitmotifs, to represent characters, places, or ideas, weaving them into the musical texture to add another dimension to the stage drama.

REAL WORLD

Franz Liszt (1811–86)

Franz Liszt was a Romantic musical legend. Born in Hungary, he was an exceptionally gifted pianist, writer, and composer who enjoyed fame across Europe. His virtuosic performances of outstanding technical skill were greeted with the kind of frenzy reserved for modern pop stars, in a phenomenon known as "Lisztomania."

